

BUILT FOR A BRAND NEW SIGNER

Your BSL Starter Kit

British Sign Language is its own language, with its own grammar - and you can start using it today. One page, works on your phone, no sign-up, nothing to install. Everything below links to real Deaf teachers.

151,000

people in the UK can use BSL (BDA)

2022

BSL recognised in law in the UK

Sept 2025

BSL GCSE began in English schools

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pounds to start - everything here is free

Start here

Three things to know before you learn a single sign. They will save you months.

1 BSL is not English on the hands

It is a complete language of its own, with its own grammar and word order. In BSL you lead with the topic, then say what happened to it - not the way an English sentence is built. So stop trying to sign word for word. Sign the picture.

Source: RNID - "It has its own grammar and is structured in a completely different way from English."

2 Learn from real signers, not drawings

Handshapes are three dimensional: palm direction, movement and facial expression all carry meaning. A flat drawing of a hand teaches the wrong shape and a learner has no way to spot it. Every sign on this page is a real video of a real BSL teacher - watch the video, copy the video.

3 Fingerspelling is your safety net

Names, place names, brands, anything you have not learned a sign for yet - you spell it. Most beginners rush it. The skill is not speed, it is smoothness: one shape flowing into the next, hand staying up. Panel two drills exactly that.

How to use this in 10 minutes a day. Three fingerspelled words you can see around you, one video sign from panel three, one deaf awareness rule from panel four. Ten minutes, out loud, every day beats an hour once a week.

Fingerspelling

Spell any word, at any speed, and drill the letters you keep fumbling.

Honest bit: this tool drills the rhythm, not the handshapes. Get the actual shapes from the alphabet video below or the official chart - this page will not pretend to draw a hand, because a wrong hand shape is worse than no hand shape.

Get the 26 handshapes right first

Commanding Hands - the BSL alphabet, right handed, signer's point of view (opens on YouTube). Watch it once, right through, then come back here and drill the rhythm.

Also excellent: **Signature - learning to fingerspell** and the free A-Z video dictionary at **british-sign.co.uk**.

60 second drill

A letter appears. Sign it, shout it out, then hit next. The clock runs for 60 seconds and the page keeps a list of the letters that tripped you up - go back to those.

Your first signs

Real teachers, real video. Tap play, then copy the hands - including the face.

The alphabet

Commanding Hands - right handed, signer's point of view (their dominant hand is on your right, which is correct for a right handed signer facing you).

Open on YouTube

Hello, please, thank you, sorry

Commanding Hands - greetings, manners and phrases for beginners. Your first proper conversation lives in this one. **Open on YouTube**

Numbers

Commanding Hands - 1 to 1 billion. Numbers come up constantly: prices, times, ages, house numbers. **Open on YouTube**

Fingerspelling practice quiz

Commanding Hands - countries. They sign, you read it. This is the other half of fingerspelling and nobody practises it. [Open on YouTube](#)

Fingerspelling for beginners

BSL learning with Mel - a slower walk through for when the alphabet video goes too fast. [Open on YouTube](#)

Family signs, animated

Farbod Media - mum, dad, sister, brother. If it will not play, use the links in the next panel instead. [Open on YouTube](#)

Two watch-outs. First, some very old BSL videos online are out of date - BSL changes like any language. Second, videos showing American Sign Language (ASL) are a different language entirely; ASL will not work here. Stick to British sources and you are fine.

Deaf awareness

The rules that matter more than vocabulary. Get these right and people will be glad you tried.

Get attention properly

Wave a hand in their eyeline, or a light tap on the shoulder or upper arm. Never shout, never throw something, never stand behind them hoping.

Keep your face visible

Expression, mouth pattern and head movement are part of BSL grammar. Do not cover your mouth, eat, or talk while turning away. Good light on your face matters.

Talk to the person, not the interpreter

If an interpreter is there, look at the Deaf person and speak to them directly - "what would you like?" not "ask her what she would like".

Applause is waving hands

In the Deaf community applause is both hands up, waving. Clapping makes a sound the person you are celebrating may not hear. Wave instead.

Say Deaf, not "hearing impaired"

Deaf - with a capital D - is a community and a culture, not a defect. Avoid "suffers from", "hearing impaired" and "normal" as the opposite of deaf.

Let them set the pace

Fingerspelling takes a beat. If you miss a name, ask for it again rather than guessing. And if you only know a little BSL, say so - effort is welcome, pretend fluency is not.

Write it down when you are stuck

Pen, paper, phone notes. Nothing wrong with it, everybody does it, and it beats repeating the same failed sign five times.

Interpreters are a legal right

Since the BSL Act 2022, BSL is a recognised language in the UK. For appointments and services, a qualified BSL interpreter is not a favour - it is access. Do not offer a family member as a stand-in.

The one-line version. Face them, get their attention, slow down, keep your hands and your face in view, and never pretend you understood when you did not.

Free practice

Everything here is free and run by British Deaf organisations, BSL teachers or UK awarding bodies.

DICTIONARY

british-sign.co.uk

Free A-Z BSL dictionary, a sign of the day, printable sheets for families and schools, plus an accredited online course if she wants a certificate.

DICTIONARY

SignBSL

The biggest free video dictionary of BSL signs, with 150+ different signers. Genuinely useful, because real life involves people who sign differently from each other - it shows you variations.

TELEVISION

BSL Zone

Free British Sign Language TV, made by Deaf producers: comedy, documentary, drama, all in BSL with subtitles. This is what ear training is for sign - watch it even when you only catch a word or two.

STRUCTURED COURSE

Signature

The UK awarding body for BSL qualifications. Free fingerspelling learning support, and their course finder is the right way to find a real Level 1 class near her.

COMMUNITY

British Deaf Association

Help and resources, community events, and the source of the 151,000 BSL users figure. Good place to understand Deaf culture rather than just vocabulary.

ON HER PHONE

Lingvano BSL

A finger-friendly sign language app with a BSL track, free to start. Good for five minutes on a bus, which is where most of her practice time will actually live.

STANDARDS

RNID

The clearest plain-English explanation of what BSL is, why it is not English, and how to be a decent communicator around Deaf people.

YOUTUBE

Commanding Hands

The channel behind most of the videos on this page. Hundreds of free BSL lessons, properly taught, filmed clearly. Subscribe and work through the beginner playlist.

Best single next step: a real class. BSL is a conversation, and a Tuesday night Level 1 course with other nervous beginners will do more for her than any app - the apps keep her ticking over in between. Signature's site is where the accredited ones are listed.

- the personal agent for Darren Hopwood, in Dorset. One page, no ads, no sign-up, no tracking. Hand it to anyone learning to sign.

Ctrl+P on a computer, or Share then Print on a phone, gives a clean print-out of everything on this page - no tabs, no buttons, no video boxes, just the words in black and white. A ready-made PDF sits here too: [bsl-starter-kit.pdf](#).

It cannot teach you handshapes on its own, it cannot correct you, and it cannot give you a conversation partner. Nothing here replaces a real signer, a real class, or a Deaf friend happy to be patient with you. The fingerspelling trainer drills rhythm only. Treat the videos and the sources below as the authority, not this page.

RNID - What is BSL

British Deaf Association

BBC - BSL GCSE from Sept 2025

BSL Act 2022, royal assent 28 April 2022

Signature - fingerspelling

SignBSL

British-Sign

BSL Zone

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